The message of Lu-diĝira to his mother -- an English prose translation

ETCSL t.5.5.1 — converted from ETCSL TEI XML (Oxford Text Archive item 2518, revised edition Oct 2006; CC BY-NC-SA 3.0).
Source file: `t.5.5.1.xml`; web: https://etcsl.orinst.ox.ac.uk/cgi-bin/etcsl.cgi?text=t.5.5.1

Paragraph labels = ETCSL composite line ranges covered by each translation paragraph. "..." = untranslatable/lost text.

1-8. Royal courier, start the journey! I want to send you to Nibru -- deliver this message! You are going on a long journey. My mother is worried, she cannot sleep [note: 1 ms. has instead:] is too (?) ..... to sleep . Although the way to her [note: 1 ms. has instead:] the closed woman's domain is blocked, deliver my letter of greeting into her hands, as she keeps asking [note: 1 ms. has instead:] and then she will not keep asking the travellers [note: 1 ms. has instead:] wayfarers about my well-being. Then my mother will be delighted, and will treat you most kindly (?) for it.

9-20. In case you should not recognise my mother, let me describe her to you. Her name is Šat-Eštar [note: 1 ms. has instead:] Šimat-Eštar , ... by her words [note: some mss. have instead:] .... Her body, face and limbs, and outer appearance are ..... She is the fair goddess of her city-quarter. Her fate has been decided since the days of her youth. Single-handed she keeps in order the house of her father-in-law. She serves humbly before her divine mistress. She knows how to look after Inana's place. She never disobeys the orders [note: 1 ms. has instead:] wishes of the king. She is energetic and causes possessions to multiply. She is loving, gentle, and lively. By nature she is a lamb, sweet butter, honey, flowing ghee.

21-31. Let me give you another description of my mother: My mother is like the bright light in the sky [note: 1 ms. has instead:] on the horizon , a doe on the hillsides. She is the morning star, shining even at noon-time [note: 1 ms. has instead:] providing plenty of light . She is precious cornelian, a topaz from Marḫaši. She is the jewellery of a king's brother, full of beauty. She is a cylinder seal of *nir* stone, an ornament like the sun [note: 1 ms. has instead:] a cornelian jewel, an ornamental drinking cup [note: 1 ms. has instead:] a cornelian ....., an ornament of *nir* stone [note: 1 ms. has instead:] a ..... jewel, a beautiful drinking cup . She is a bracelet of tin, a ring of *antasura* metal. She is a nugget of shining gold and silver, but which is living and draws breath ..... [note: 1 ms. has instead:] ..... and breathing [note: 1 ms. has instead:] ..... place ..... . She is an alabaster statuette of a protective goddess standing on a pedestal of lapis lazuli. She is a polished rod of ivory [note: 2 mss. have instead:] a living figurine (?) , with limbs full of beauty [note: 1 ms. has instead:] ..... [note: 1 ms. has instead:] full of pleasure .

32-39. Let me give you a third description of my mother: My mother is rain from heaven [note: 1 ms. has instead:] timely rain , water for the finest seeds. She is a bountiful harvest of fully-grown fine barley [note: 1 ms. has instead:] ripe, exceedingly fine barley [note: 1 ms. has instead:] heavenly ..... [note: 1 ms. has instead:] ripe maturity (?) ..... . She is a garden of ..... [note: 1 ms. has instead:] delights , full of laughter [note: 1 ms. has instead:] filled with rejoicing . She is a well-irrigated pine tree, an adorned juniper [note: 1 ms. has instead:] adorned with pine-cones . She is early fruit, the products [note: 1 ms. has instead:] garden's yield of the first month. She is an irrigation ditch bringing fertilising water to the garden plots. She is a sweet Dilmun date, a prime date much sought after.

40-46. Let me give you a fourth description of my mother: My mother fills the festivals and offerings with joy. She is an *akitum* offering [note: 1 ms. has instead:] the *akitum* festival , awesome (?) to look upon. She is the offspring, the child [note: 1 ms. has instead:] the daughter of the king, a song of abundance. She is a place of entertainment set up for delights. [note: 1 ms. adds:] ..... fruit ..... abundance. She is a lover, a loving heart who never becomes sated with pleasure. She is the good news that the captive will return to his mother [note: 1 ms. has instead:] to celebrate .

47-52. Let me give you a fifth description of my mother: My mother is a palm-tree, with the sweetest fragrance. She is a chariot of juniper wood, a sedan chair of boxwood. She is a fine cloth [note: 1 ms. has instead:] a good ..... perfumed with refined oil. She is a bunch of grapes, a garland (?) growing luxuriantly [note: 1 ms. has instead:] perfect in luxuriant growth . She [note: 1 ms. has instead:] My mother is a phial made from an ostrich egg, overflowing [note: 1 ms. has instead:] full with finest [note: 1 ms. has instead:] perfumed oil. [note: 1 ms. adds:] She is a fair woman, accompanied by a protective goddess ..... She is a woman who will show you compassion like (?) Aruru, ... born .....

53-54. When, thanks to the descriptions I have given you, you stand in her (?) radiant presence, tell her: “Your beloved son Lu-diĝira is in good health.” [note: 1 ms. has instead:] The descriptions I have given you describe (?) her (?) appearance. A most fair woman accompanied by many protective goddesses, she is my mother. Pay attention, ... joyfully .....: “Your beloved son Lu-diĝira is in good health .....”, tell her ..... *(1 line fragmentary)*